



Captain MARVEL

| By Sharda Ugra |

THE SIKKIMESE SNIPER

NICKNAME Bhai

DATE OF BIRTH

December 15, 1976

PLACE OF BIRTH

Tinkitam, Sikkim

HEIGHT 1.73 m (5 ft 8 in)

PLAYING POSITION

Striker

CURRENT CLUB

Mohun Bagan (in dispute)

INDIA RECORD

105 matches, 42 goals

CLUB CAREER

EAST BENGAL

1993, 1994, 1995, 1997,
1998, 2003, 2004, 2005

JCT 1996

BURY 1999, 2000, 2001

MOHUN BAGAN 2002,
2006, 2007, 2008

GOAL TALLY

INDIA 42

EAST BENGAL 146

JCT 25

MOHUN BAGAN 45

Statistics: Gautam Roy

Bangalore, 2001. The Indian football team, heading off for practice in their bus. The television's on and India are playing Australia. Except it's cricket. Faces are upturned, expressions transfixed. Suddenly, their striker explodes off his seat and turns his back to the screen. He is 25 and wiry, made it seems of mahogany. Turn it off, he says. Stop watching and turn off the damn TV. Think football, focus, we're going to training. We're the Indian football team, we're stars too, dammit, we're as good as they are.

That is Bhaichung Bhutia in a snapshot. It is all you need to know about India's captain and highest goalscorer and it is this: that he is a professional and that he demands respect for his profession.

It is because Bhutia feels what everybody who follows Indian football senses. Support for the national team is like a heartbeat. It is constant, steady and usually you cannot hear it. Except when a moment arrives, like the Nehru Cup did. Then, the groundswell gathers force and it reverberates. Unmistakably, emphatically. For the last 15 years, Bhutia has been one with this heartbeat. He has, in fact, been its amplifier.

The 32-year-old from Tinkitam is Indian football's mascot, its brand ambassador, its spokesman. He is also a leap in its slow evolution, from amateur to professional, the first Indian to close towards 50 international goals from more than 100 games, the first Indian to take his game to Europe, a pioneer, a path-breaker, an agitationist, a forthright, fiery leader of his sport.

Talk to Bhutia and in an era of cautious, soundbite-schooled athletes his defiance for authority and pure freedom of expres-

sion is refreshing.

Currently embroiled in a bitter war with his club Mohun Bagan who have suspended him for six months without pay for missing a friendly exhibition match, he leaps into answers like he would at the end of a long cross. "Their intention is to destroy a player's life... there is this kind of *mentality* and it needs to change." The longest frustration of his career? "Infrastructure—clubs like Mohun Bagan, East Bengal and Mohammedan Sporting are a hundred years old, they haven't changed, they don't have a proper training ground with a bathroom." His fractious relationship with former coach Syed Naeemuddin? "It was purely an on-field thing. Ninety per cent of players under him had differences with his style of coaching." Bang, bang, bang. He doesn't hold back, hammering home his point like shots on goal.

Make no mistake, though, this is no moaning prima donna. Bhutia has been at the centre of a revival and surge in results around the Indian team. India have won three tournaments in the last two years. Along with two Nehru Cups, the AFC Challenge Cup has given them entry into the 2011 Asian Cup, the continental championships, after nearly a quarter of a century.

National coach Bob Houghton is sure that without Bhutia, India wouldn't have had those wins. "Not because of the technical skills of a single player but what Bhutia brings to the team. He is India's only superstar but he's a normal boy, a great team man and the best example to the others. He is very valuable to Indian football."

That value to any team Bhutia plays for cannot, his peers say, be quantified like his current annual earnings (Rs 50-60 lakh). Old club coach Subhash Bhowmick says when Bhutia pulls on the India T-shirt, he is a force multiplied. "Like Leander Paes.